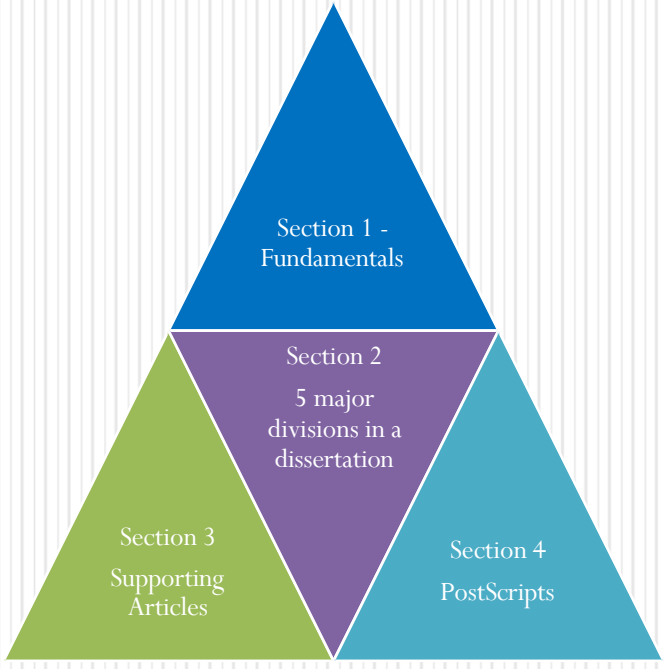
Foundation 5

Dissertation Structures

Session 1.8



The structure of your dissertation is the skeleton that supports your work. It may *not* be weak.

Cronje's structure

- I am often asked questions about the "Structure" of a thesis/essay/article, and what it should look like.
- A thesis/article/dissertation/essay is almost identical:

The logic of it is:

- Introduction: This is my field, this is what is missing – therefore I want to argue my thesis statement; but to find an answer to my thesis statement, I need to answer four sub questions, a, b c and d.
- Literature survey: The reason why I am doing it is because the literature says that this is what is needed, these are the concepts that fit into the conceptual framework, and this is how you should be looking for them.

- Research design: So this is how I am going to find out if my thesis statement is true or not;
- Body:
  - Data: So after applying my plan, I found the following OR so this is what I suggest and this is why you need to believe me.
- Conclusion: Thus, this is my contribution to our field of knowledge, this is how I fit in with the rest of the literature in the world, and specifically stuff that came across my desk after I finished this research, and, if I had to continue with a PHD on this subject, then these are the types of questions that I would ask (OR if this is a PhD, then once I am a professor, these are the questions I will get my students to answer, OR for an article - now that you have read this article, these are the questions you should be asking.

Introduction

- Background information / Purpose of study, research objectives
- Problem statement / Significance, motivation
- Definitions, assumptions, limitations/ Thesis, delineation, research questions
- Brief chapter overview

Literature review

- Introduction
- Broad (context, theory base)
- Detailed (works organised by topic/idea)
- Conclusion

Method

- Introduction / research design
- Research instruments / data
- Analysis / limitations
- Ethics/ conclusion

Body

- Chapter: introduction, sections, subconclusions
- Chapter: introduction, sections, subconclusions
- Chapter: introduction, sections, subconclusions

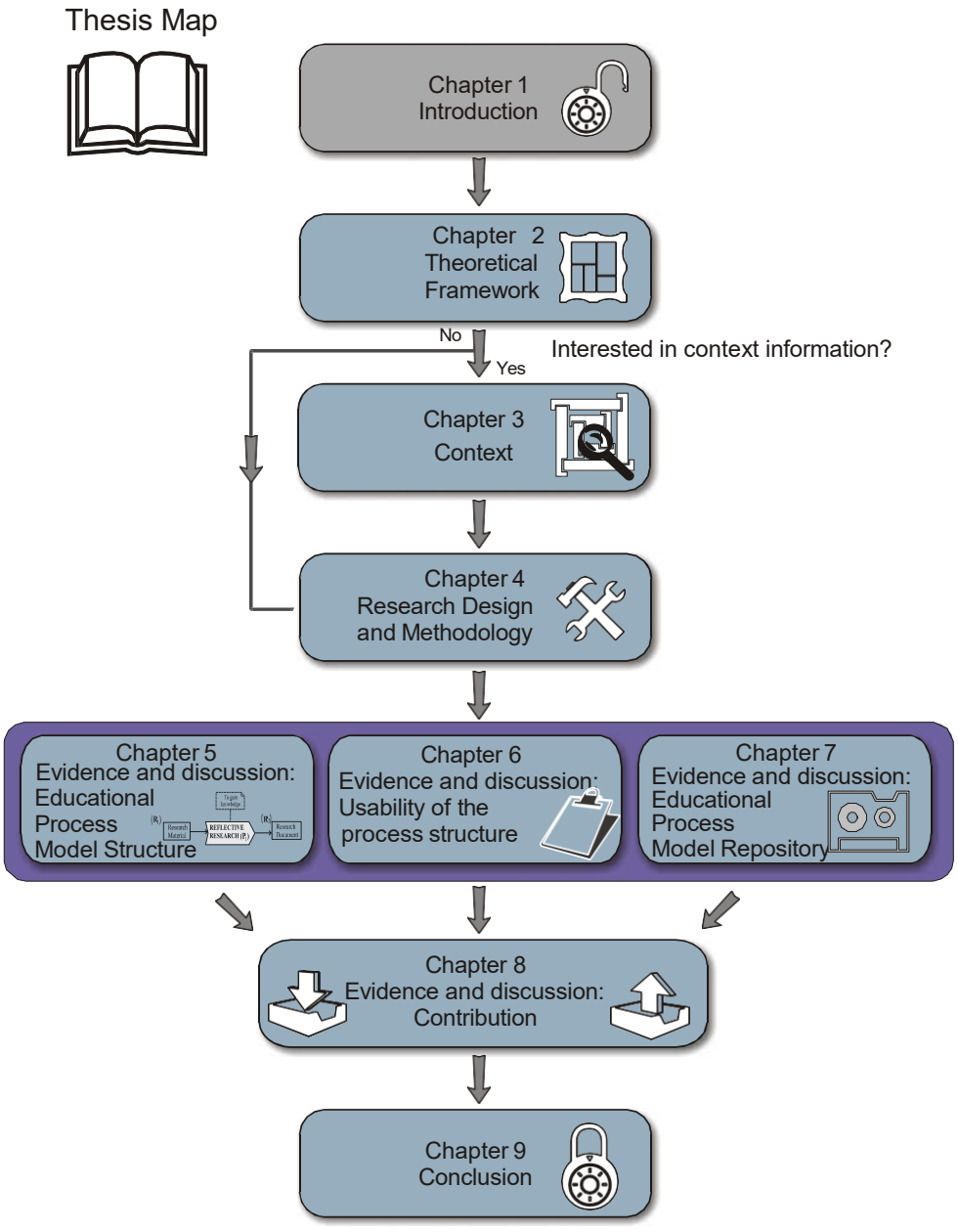
Conclusion

- Summary of findings
- Conclusions
- Summary of contributions
- Future research

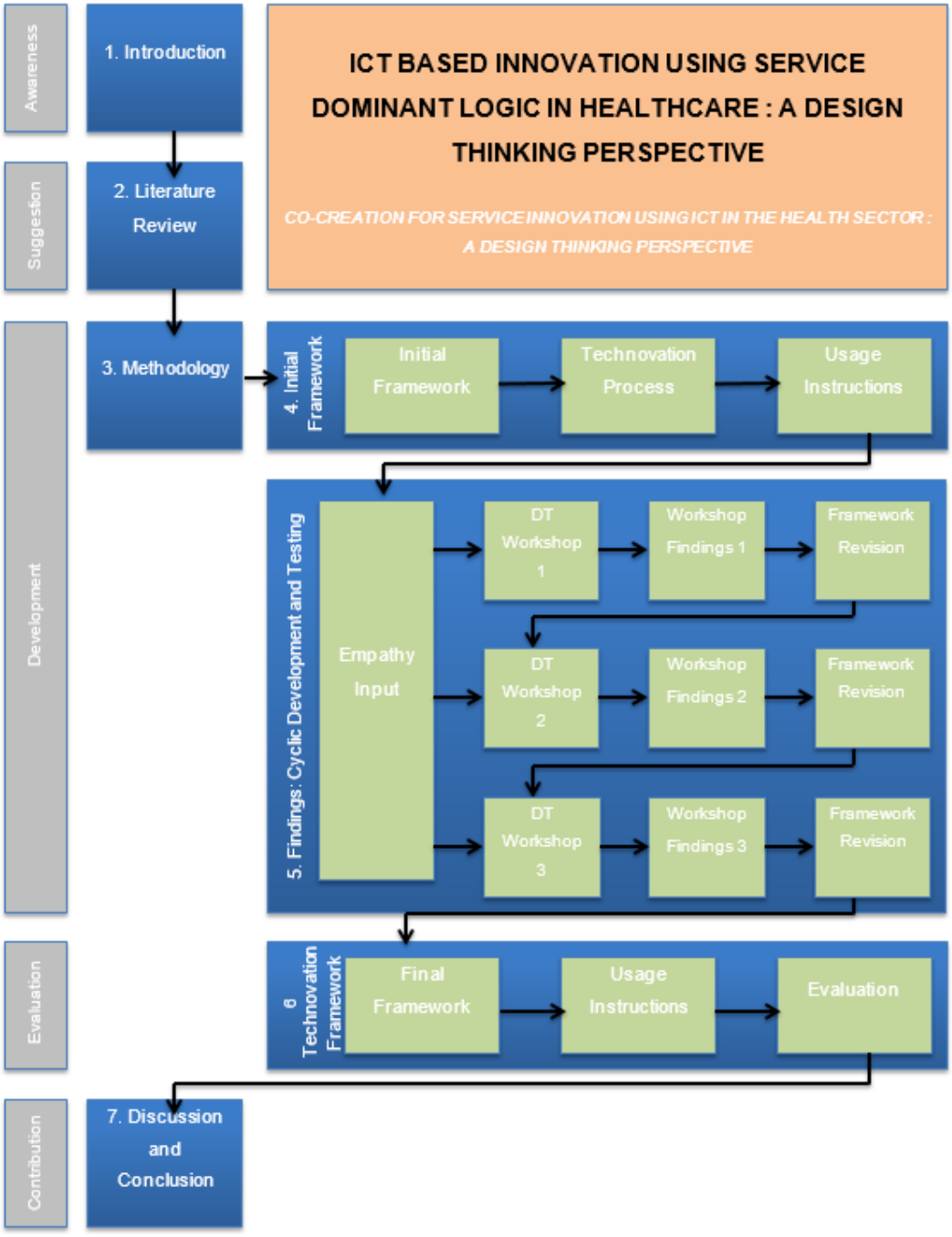
Contents and order

- This structure forms a logical order or argument
- Introduction: *what we want to know ..*
- Literature: *what do we know?*
- Method: *how are we going to find it out?*
- Body: *what did we find?*
- Conclusions: *what did we add to the pool of knowledge?*

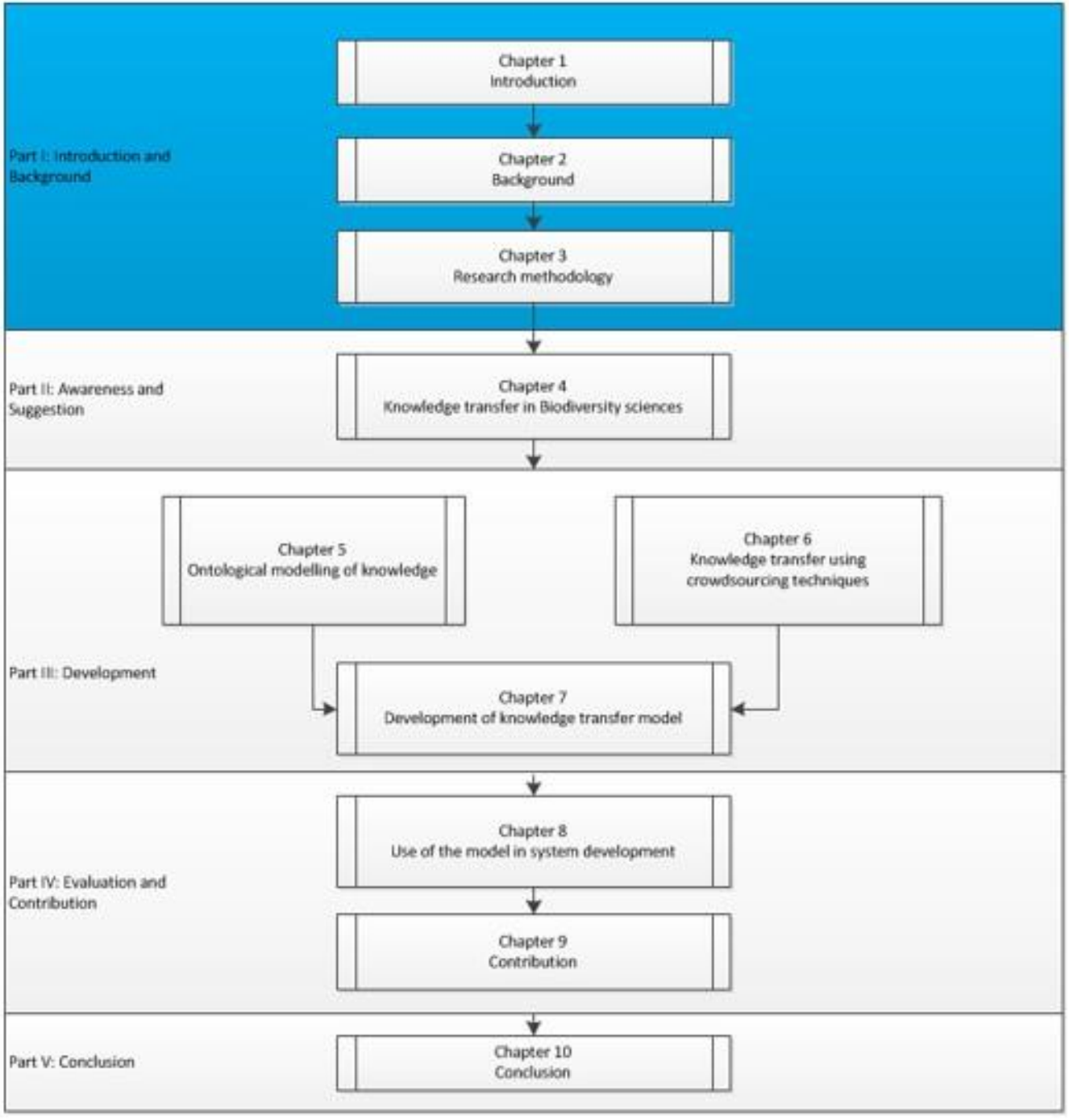
Example of thesis Map



Alex Marufu


Awareness
Suggestion
Development
Evaluation
Contribution
1. Introduction
2. Literature Review
3. Methodology
ICT BASED INNOVATION USING SERVICE DOMINANT LOGIC IN HEALTHCARE : A DESIGN THINKING PERSPECTIVE
CO-CREATION FOR SERVICE INNOVATION USING ICT IN THE HEALTH SECTOR : A DESIGN THINKING PERSPECTIVE
4. Initial Framework
Initial Framework
Technovation Process
Usage Instructions
5. Findings: Cyclic Development and Testing
Empathy Input
DT Workshop 1
Workshop Findings 1
Framework Revision
DT Workshop 2
Workshop Findings 2
Framework Revision
DT Workshop 3
Workshop Findings 3
Framework Revision
6 Technovation Framework
Final Framework
Usage Instructions
Evaluation
7. Discussion and Conclusion

Kiptoo


Part I: Introduction and Background
Chapter 1
Introduction
Chapter 2
Background
Chapter 3
Research methodology
Part II: Awareness and Suggestion
Chapter 4
Knowledge transfer in Biodiversity sciences
Part III: Development
Chapter 5
Ontological modelling of knowledge
Chapter 6
Knowledge transfer using crowdsourcing techniques
Chapter 7
Development of knowledge transfer model
Part IV: Evaluation and Contribution
Chapter 8
Use of the model in system development
Chapter 9
Contribution
Part V: Conclusion
Chapter 10
Conclusion

Thesis Length

- The correct length for a dissertation is as long as it needs to be to contain all the required components and to arrive at a good conclusion, and no longer than that.
- Aim for more or less 80% of what your institution prescribe
- If you must make your dissertation shorter, take the number of pages that you need to shorten the dissertation, multiply by 340, and then divide that number by the number of pages in your dissertation.
- E.g 100x340/500 = 68 words per page.
- Start by cutting sections, then paragraphs, then sentences.

Typical length of dissertation

	Percentage	Thesis	Full Masters	PhD
Introduction	10%	10	12	30
Literature Review	20%	20	24	60
Method	15%	15	18	45
Body	45%	45	54	135
Conclusion	10%	10	12	30
		100	120	300

General guideline:

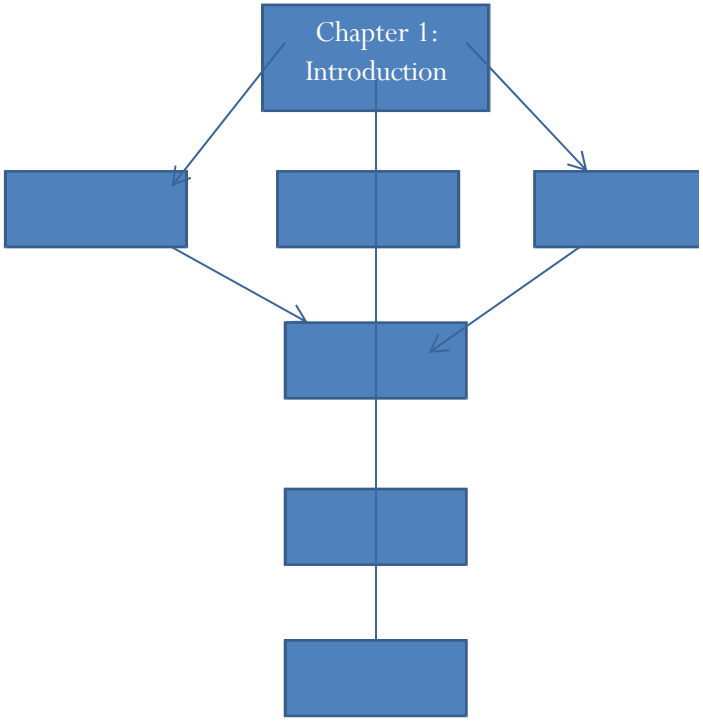
- Chapter length 20-25 pages (1.5 spacing)
- Major headings every 4-5 pages

Heading

- Reason for using headings – provides structure like a chapter map.
- If you suffer to find an appropriate heading – probably different concepts within one section.
- Formatting of headings: Same heading per level
  - **HEADING 1**
  - **Heading 2**
  - ***Heading 3***
- Careful of too many levels – max 3 to 4. Human mind suffers to conceptualize more.
- Avoid complex combined headings e.g 2.3.1.(i)

- Use your introduction and summary to explain your structure to your reader.
- Introduction should dealt with what will be covered below.
- Conclusion should without repetition pull together the key points.
- Use a dynamic table of contents and graphical representations of your document to guide your reader.
- Try to create your table of contents *before you start writing*.
- Use tools such as Mindmanager to assist in your structure.

- Practical: Draw a conceptual map of your dissertation with Chapter headings e.g Chapter 1: Introduction



The more you can make your work adhere to the standard structure of dissertations, the easier your task will be ..

"Your bone structure's fine Mr Wilson, you just need re-pointing."

To session 1.6